

Beyond Academic Integrity: Navigating Institutional and Disciplinary Anxieties About AI-Assisted Authorship in Technical and Professional Communication

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Abstract

Generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) tools are already being implemented for a variety of writing tasks in workplaces, where individual (human) authorship is valued less than the efficient production of text. But policies regarding

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AI use in higher education continue to prioritize academic integrity, focusing on narrowly defined notions of authorship that do not reflect the realities of workplace writing. Through an analysis of 100 university policies on AI, this article shows how AI tools create a tension for faculty in technical and professional communication who must operate within institutional or departmental policies for AI use but must also prepare writers for workplace authorship.

Keywords

artificial intelligence, authorship, professional communication, academic integrity, institutional policies

Artificial intelligence (AI) tools provide a variety of benefits for technical and professional writers, including increased speed and efficiency, better quality brainstorming and data analysis, and sentence-level grammatical improvements, and these benefits are already being seen in many industries (Getchell et al., 2022). Whereas *AI* refers to machine or computer learning as well as a field focused on problem-solving, *generative AI* (GenAI) refers to large language models that leverage data sets to engage with prompts using statistically probable responses (IBM, 2023; Manning, 2020). Cardon et al. (2023) found that working adults in the United States use GenAI tools such as ChatGPT for professional writing activities (e.g., generating ideas, researching a topic, drafting, editing). Further, 67% of executives and 64% of managers “believe generative AI can help them communicate more effectively,” with early adopters holding positive views of GenAI tools related to workplace productivity and the quality of their work (p. 2).

Within the higher education context, however, institutional responses to generative AI have primarily been focused on issues related to academic integrity and plagiarism, and use of AI is often seen as being at odds with “original work.” Since OpenAI released ChatGPT to the public in November 2022, colleges and universities have scrambled to create policies and guidelines for acceptable GenAI use, reigniting long-standing debates and anxieties about the relationship between technology, ethics, and authorship (Graham, 2023; Johnson, 2023; Morrison, 2023). Institutional responses to AI include outright bans on the use of generative AI by students or faculty, advice on how to protect the integrity of curricula by making assignments and courses “AI-proof,” and cautions about the accuracy of AI detection tools (Caulfield, 2023).

But such policies can leave technical and professional communication (TPC) faculty in a bind: Although institutions as a whole seem wary of generative AI, TPC research underscores that students will need to have

knowledge of AI writing tools to be successful in the workplace, emphasizes the differences between classroom-based and workplace-based writing practices, and suggests that students can develop ethical and technical proficiencies in the classroom through AI-assisted writing (Getchell et al., 2022). TPC instructors, then, are in a unique position in that their courses prepare students to communicate effectively in the workplace, so they must consider industry, rather than academic, notions of writing processes, research, and authorship (Findlay, 2019). Many argue that the true task at hand is to train students—and themselves—to use AI tools in an effective and ethical manner and to resist framing discussions of AI in the discourse of literacy crises (Byrd, 2023; Gonzales, 2023).

Thus, faculty in TPC must navigate institutional policies that are less favorable toward AI and may provide faculty with little guidance about how to productively integrate AI tools. They must also prepare students for current and future landscapes of AI-assisted workplace writing, often while handling their own uncertainty about using AI in their teaching and research. Although this uncertainty creates a challenge for now, and the emergence of generative AI tools may represent a significant change in how TPC faculty discuss the concept of authorship with students, we argue that it is a change in degree rather than in kind. That is, TPC faculty will continue to prepare students for the realities and exigencies of workplace writing while grappling with institutional or departmental policies about academic writing and plagiarism—just as they have done with the emergence of previous writing and literacy technologies.

To call attention to the types of AI policies under which TPC faculty must operate, and to illustrate the productive ways in which TPC faculty can model effective and ethical coauthorship with AI, we used two AI tools to conduct a thematic analysis of university AI policies. In this article, we present our initial findings from this preliminary analysis, offering recommendations for balancing institutional anxieties with course-level goals and practices.

Walking the Talk: Using AI to Analyze University AI Policies

To better understand the ways AI is framed within higher education policies, we searched for college and university policies related to AI and discovered a publicly available data set consisting of policies and guidelines gathered from 100 U.S. universities in April through June 2023 (Caulfield, 2023). The data set includes both official policy statements and broader sets of university guidelines advising faculty on how best to approach or prevent the

use of AI in their courses. Although these policies represent both public and private universities in 37 states, the data represent only research institutions with an R1 or R2 rating, so policies at other institutional types may reflect different institutional values and resources. We decided that despite the limited range of institutional types, this data set was sufficient for our preliminary analysis using AI tools.

To investigate the potential of AI for TPC and to model effective and ethical practices that can be used in the classroom, we used two AI tools to assist with our preliminary analysis of this data set: ChatGPT and ATLAS.ti's OpenAI coding function. GenAI tools are gaining popularity for qualitative research, but many questions still remain about the efficacy and ethics of using GenAI for data analysis (Marshall & Naff, 2023); therefore, we incorporated two GenAI tools into our preliminary analysis to mimic "the coordination and calibration of multiple researchers interacting with the same rich data" (p. 7).

ChatGPT is a widely used, conversation-based GenAI chatbot launched in late 2022, and ATLAS.ti is a beta version of AI coding launched in April 2023, incorporating OpenAI to help researchers create coding schemes for text-based documents. We selected ChatGPT and ATLAS.ti for this analysis because while both rely on the OpenAI language model, they are quite distinct in the type of inputs they allow as well as in the scope and format of the results. For instance, the interface of ChatGPT required us to copy and paste the full text of the data set into the chat box in segments but then allowed us to make multiple requests and ask open-ended questions to guide the analysis. In contrast, at the time we conducted this research, ATLAS.ti did not allow specific prompting for the AI coding tool; rather, when we selected the "AI Coding" option, ATLAS.ti generated an inductive coding scheme for the full data set. Although the ATLAS.ti interface did not allow us to ask OpenAI to refine this coding scheme, it did provide all of the quotations in the data set that were tagged with each code, with the option to review the frequency with which each code was applied and any quotations to which more than one code was applied. In other words, while ATLAS.ti provided us with a detailed look at all of the individual instances of each code it created, ChatGPT provided broad themes across the data set as a whole. We see these two sets of results as complementary and instructive.

We began our inductive analysis of the data set by inputting the raw data into ChatGPT and asking the tool to identify themes in the data without providing any additional parameters. ChatGPT offered a list of 10 themes with an accompanying description of each theme. Because we interpreted some of the themes as overlapping (e.g., the themes "unique course contexts"

and “individual instructor discretion”), we worked together and with ChatGPT to consolidate, which resulted in 8 clearly defined themes. We prompted ChatGPT to elaborate on each of these 8 themes by providing a list of institutions associated with each theme and examples of policy language corresponding to each theme. To ensure reliability, we checked ChatGPT’s output from our prompt with the data set by manually searching for keywords and phrases from the theme elaborations. For the theme “coauthorship,” ChatGPT failed to provide a list of institutions or quotes representing this theme. As a result, we manually searched for “coauthorship” and related terms such as “collaboration” and “AI-assisted writing” in the data set and found only one institution that discussed coauthorship. Table 1 lists the results of this AI-assisted thematic analysis.

ATLAS.ti’s AI coder initially provided a set of 96 quotations with 147 code labels for the data set—a coding scheme so expansive that it was nearly unusable. Nevertheless, the expansive coding scheme highlighted a few prominent themes (e.g., “academic integrity,” “plagiarism,” and “cheating”) that reflect the anxieties about academic dishonesty articulated in these policies. Although some codes were frequently applied but too general to be useful for this thematic analysis (e.g., “education”), the vast majority of these codes (126 out of 147) were applied fewer than five times in the data set, and many of these 126 codes were similar to the point of redundancy (e.g., “Academic Misconduct,” “Academic Dishonesty,” and “Academic Integrity”). Because ATLAS.ti’s AI coding function did not allow for reprompting, or “training,” in order to refine results, we reviewed the initial coding scheme together and manually merged or deleted unnecessary or repetitive code names, a process Saldana (2021) referred to as “lumping,” or “subsuming codes into broader codes or categories” (p. 45). This process resulted in a list of 12 ATLAS.ti codes, which are outlined in Table 2. Although ATLAS.ti did not provide descriptions or definitions for any of its codes, we have included in Table 2 descriptions that reflect our interpretation of each code and comments about any modifications we made to the original ATLAS.ti scheme that resulted in changes to the code.

Following Geisler’s (2004) recommendations for revising a coding scheme to reflect the research team’s growing understanding of a phenomenon, we worked with one another and with the analyses produced by ChatGPT and ATLAS.ti’s OpenAI coder to develop a set of categories that best described university policies about AI. We consolidated categories about the data, comparing and contrasting the broad themes provided by ChatGPT with coded quotations provided by ATLAS.ti in order to

Table 1. AI-Assisted Thematic Analysis: ChatGPT-4 (OpenAI, 2023).

Theme	Description*	Number of Institutions ChatGPT Linked With Theme	Example Quotation From Policy Language
Individual instructor discretion	Instructors may decide whether to allow the use of AI in their courses.	11	"Discuss academic integrity with students, including what constitutes original work and plagiarism in your field, what type of assistance is and is not permitted." (Alabama)
Transparency and communication	Faculty are encouraged to set clear expectations for students through syllabus and assignment language.	63	"Faculty should be transparent about what students are permitted to use and under what conditions." (Connecticut)
Academic integrity	Institutions are concerned about preventing plagiarism and cheating.	33	"Using ChatGPT to generate essays for submission for lower division writing will be considered a violation of academic integrity." (University of California, Irvine)
Varied approaches	Institutions take a wide variety of stances and approaches in framing their policies.	63	"Instead of forbidding its use, however, we might investigate which questions AI poses for us as teachers and for our students as learners." (Georgetown)
Educational value	Some universities see AI as having the potential to enhance literacy and learning.	9	"These types of apps are not going away and will no doubt proliferate in the future ... so encouraging students to

(continued)

Table 1. (continued)

Theme	Description*	Number of Institutions ChatGPT Linked With Theme	Example Quotation From Policy Language
Evolving policies	The policies are framed as works-in-progress.	33	use them productively could be seen as an important contribution to information literacy.” (Michigan) “Until university leaders develop this guidance, students and faculty should follow the Student Honor Code and Faculty Handbook, and work together to have conversations about expectations in the classroom.” (North Carolina, Chapel Hill) “Online ‘AI Detection’ programs exist, but they are not well-tested and may not be accurate.” (Miami)
Detection challenges	Some institutions caution faculty against trying to detect AI-generated content and encourage prevention rather than detection	16	
Coauthorship	This approach to academic integrity describes AI as a writing or research partner.	1*	“All content generated through the use of ChatGPT is to be understood and identified as ‘co-authored’ by the user and the AI.” (Wesleyan)*

*Provided by authors.

determine the extent to which the two sets of results aligned with each other and formulate some takeaways from these results. This process aligns with Geisler's (2004) recommendations for calculating frequencies in coded data and subsequently seeing, interpreting, and naming patterns (or lack of patterns) in those data. We will now discuss this combined analysis and its implications.

Discussion

Despite the different interfaces and analytical approaches that ChatGPT and ATLAS.ti's OpenAI coder afford, the two tools produced some similar results. For instance, both ChatGPT and ATLAS.ti coder highlighted the emphasis on academic integrity that currently dominates the language of institutional policies about AI. In its initial summary of the theme, ChatGPT described the preservation of academic integrity as "a paramount concern, with universities explicitly stating that plagiarism, including AI-generated content, is not tolerated" (OpenAI, 2023).

At the same time, both AI analyses highlighted policies that acknowledged the potential for AI tools to contribute to academic innovation and educational value, even if the policies were not clear about what those innovations might be. For instance, ATLAS.ti tagged Northeastern University's policy with the "positive innovation" code because the policy reminds faculty that "while it may be tempting to focus on potential negative consequences, AI also presents an opportunity to make modifications in our teaching that will improve and personalize student learning, and even to make creative use of the tools."

Finally, both AI tools noted that university policies commonly defer to instructors to develop and communicate course expectations about AI use but that the policies provide few details about how to develop course-specific guidelines: ATLAS.ti, for instance, identified "ambiguity" as a recurring theme in the data set whereas ChatGPT identified themes such as "varied approaches" and "evolving policies," suggesting that university administrators may be unsure how to advise faculty at this stage. This tension between top-down policies and instructor discretion aligns with previous research on AI policies. Although a faculty-driven approach may be helpful for students, a survey by Cardon et al. (2023) found that the top-two instructor preferences were for AI-assisted writing policy to be developed at the school or university level (33.7%, or 114 respondents) and at the department level (24.3%, or 82 respondents).

Table 2. AI-Assisted Thematic Analysis: ATLAS.ti (2023).

Code Name	Description/Comments	Number of Quotations Labeled With Code	Example Quotation From Policy Language
Academic integrity	Includes discussions of plagiarism, academic honesty/dishonesty, and cheating Authors merged “academic misconduct,” “academic dishonesty,” “academic integrity,” “plagiarism,” and “cheating” codes.	66	“If a student uses text generated from ChatGPT and passes it off as their own writing, without acknowledging or citing the influence of ChatGPT in their process, they are in violation of the university’s academic honor code.” (University of California, Berkeley)
Technology	Includes comparisons between GenAI and other tools and descriptions of how the tools function or operate Authors merged “technology” and “writing technology” codes.	25	“...given that ChatGPT is built partly on the common academic task of ‘entering things into computers to generate outputs,’ how [does] it substantively differ in impact from technologies like Grammarly, which are commonly used by academics.” (Colorado Boulder)
Transparency	Encourages faculty to set clear expectations for students	21	“Regardless of the approach selected, faculty should explicitly discuss with students the approach and its underlying rationale.” (Delaware)
Ethics	Emphasizes honesty, fairness, and proper acknowledgement of AI use	14	“...the only way a student could ethically use ChatGPT would be if the program was required for a class project.” (Emory)

(continued)

Table 2. (continued)

Code Name	Description/Comments	Number of Quotations Labeled With Code	Example Quotation From Policy Language
Ambiguity	Authors merged "ethics" and "AI ethics" codes. Lacks certainty or clarity in guidance	11	"We have yet to determine where to set the boundaries of AI use in our classes or our professional lives." (Kansas)
Citation	Acknowledges and delineates AI-generated content as distinct from students' original writing	9	"...if a student is using ChatGPT, they need to cite it and acknowledge it, and mark it in some way in the paper, such as using quotation marks, just like they would with any other material source." (Florida State)
Teaching practices	Discusses classroom strategies faculty may adopt related to AI Authors merged "teaching methods" and "instructional practice" codes.	7	"Move away from the five paragraph essay. Chatbots can follow this format easily." (New Mexico)
Positive innovation	Emphasizes that AI can enhance learning	6	"While it may be tempting to focus on potential negative consequences, AI also presents an opportunity to make modifications in our teaching that will improve and personalize student learning." (Northeastern)

(continued)

Table 2. (continued)

Code Name	Description/Comments	Number of Quotations Labeled With Code	Example Quotation From Policy Language
Collaborative decision-making	Stresses collaboration between faculty and students on approaches to AI use	5	"...instructors might partner with their students to develop the policies around usage in the course." (Columbia)
Integration	Discusses incorporating rather than banning AI use in the curriculum	5	"Ideally, we would come to a place where this technology can be integrated into our instruction in meaningful ways, in the same way that over time math teachers integrated calculators into their teaching." (Michigan State)
Curriculum concerns	Considers ways to maintain high standards for students	4	"In the absence of specific university-wide policies, we'll each have to determine our own means for protecting the integrity of our curriculum." (Brigham Young)
Academic freedom	Mentions faculty's ability to make their own decisions about AI use	2	"Just like most things we do here at UB, instructors have complete academic freedom to do what they want to do in their classroom." (Buffalo)

Note. Coding names were generated from the prompt "AI policies U.S. universities."

Although the two AI tools highlighted some common themes, there were several important differences between the two analyses. For example, the prevalence of some themes—even the common themes—differed considerably between the two analyses. For instance, ChatGPT associated one third of the university statements ($n = 33$) with the theme “academic integrity” whereas ATLAS.ti applied the academic integrity code to twice as many university statements ($n = 66$). Conversely, ChatGPT perceived “transparency and communication” to be one of the most prevalent themes, associating it with 63 university statements, whereas ATLAS.ti only applied this code 21 times. Also, the ATLAS.ti codes were often less broad than the ChatGPT themes, and they highlighted specific teaching practices and writing genres that GenAI tools might affect (e.g., the five paragraph essay) in addition to broader issues such as ethics and technology.

Toward Coauthoring With AI in TPC

Some key themes from our results have implications for TPC faculty. Although institutions as a whole may be narrowly focused on academic integrity, the language of university policies, we argue, reveals opportunities for positive innovation in preparing students for workplace writing.

As we described, university AI policies focused on academic integrity were quite common in this data set, and the language of those policies was often much less ambiguous than that of policies promoting instructor and student innovation in AI use. Such integrity-focused policies often outlined specific guidance rooted in university honor codes and similar documents when discussing unacceptable AI use, such as Carnegie Mellon’s statement: “CMU’s academic integrity policy addresses the unauthorized use of such tools. Among the three categories of academic integrity violations (i.e., cheating, plagiarism, and unauthorized assistance), “unauthorized assistance” applies most directly.” In contrast, policies on how AI might be productively used in the classroom are much less clear: Many policies acknowledge that AI might be useful and that students could benefit from learning to use it but provide no examples or explanations of how this integration might happen. Whereas instructions on how to prevent AI use in classes are specific (e.g., the University of Illinois’s guidance to “do writing assignments in class...have students compose a handwritten essay or write a shorter reflection paper on a current topic in class”), guidance on innovation and integration of AI use in classes is speculative and uncertain (e.g., Colorado State University’s advice: “*If* there are any acceptable uses, explain those for your students”).

The emphasis on academic integrity in this data set aligns with previous research indicating that much of the conversation about AI in higher education has been focused on plagiarism and cheating (Cotton et al., 2023; Jamieson, 2022). But the tone of conversations about AI in higher education is strikingly different from that of such conversations in the business sector, in which discussions about the types of transformative innovations enabled by AI are just as common (Cardon et al., 2023) as are anxious discussions about negative consequences such as worker replacement. Thus, academia's narrow framing of AI as a threat to academic integrity and original authorship and its uncertainty about how faculty might productively integrate AI technologies into their courses signal a disconnect between classroom writing and the kinds of literacies and practices expected of professionals. But given the instructor discretion emphasized in university policies, this disconnect presents an opportunity for TPC faculty to respond to AI-related anxieties in pedagogically focused, discipline-relevant ways.

As universities struggle to articulate specific ways in which faculty can productively utilize AI technologies in their classrooms, TPC faculty should embrace the uncertainty that accompanies the new technological landscape of AI-assisted writing and focus on helping students determine their roles as writers in relation to their AI assistants. In reviewing the initial analysis provided by ChatGPT, we were intrigued by the "coauthorship" theme, partly because it departs from the more restrictive emphasis on plagiarism and academic dishonesty and partly because ChatGPT highlighted the theme even though only one university in the data set, Wesleyan, made any sort of comment about coauthorship: "All content generated through the use of ChatGPT is to be understood and identified as 'co-authored' by the user and the AI." The concept of coauthorship articulated in Wesleyan's policy coupled with codes such as "positive innovation" identified by ATLAS.ti suggest that some universities do see positive opportunities for "welcoming students to engage with new technologies and learn about how they work" (Gonzales, 2023, p. 215).

Although most university policies in the data set prioritize single human authorship as opposed to human and AI coauthorship, TPC faculty can leverage the notion of coauthorship to help students "develop writerly tactics that reorient their relationship to and beliefs about writing" in preparation for workplace writing that "frequently demands an erasure of writerly identity" (Findlay, 2019, p. 5). Although as Dobrin (2023) pointed out, colleagues and supervisors in the professional world are less interested in the process used to generate a text than in that text's successful outcome, in TPC classrooms, we recommend incorporating AI use into identifiable

moments in the writing process, such as organizing information into genre-appropriate structures and generating first drafts of texts. We also recommend asking students to identify goals for their AI use and assign tasks to the AI tools and to themselves in order to establish the nature and the scope of the collaboration (as they might do in a group project).

Thus, the university AI policies provided instructor discretion that allows TPC faculty to steer the conversation away from questions about individual authorship grounded in academic-writing frameworks and toward collaborative models of writing with technology. To do so, TPC faculty must openly communicate with students about a given technology, discuss its benefits and drawbacks, outline how it can or should be used as an AI-assisted writing tool, and perhaps most important, practice alongside the students rather than wait to become experts in the technology (a futile endeavor, given how rapidly new and existing tools are advancing). A few university policies seem to advocate for this collaborative approach, including the University of Arizona's policy, which provides one of the few specific suggestions for AI use in this data set: "If the text generated by ChatGPT is used as a starting point for original research or writing, then it can be a useful tool for generating ideas and suggestions." Although this suggestion still draws a harsh distinction between "original" and AI-assisted writing that may be difficult to flesh out in practice, such an approach offers an opportunity to emphasize students' "critical analysis and interpretation of computational data" (Berdanier & Alley, 2023, p. 584) when gathering input from tools such as ChatGPT. We have tried to model this collaborative and critical approach to writing with AI in conducting this analysis by noting which contributions were made by ChatGPT and ATLAS.ti and which ones were made by human authors and by outlining the limitations of the AI tools and our own choices.

Another way that TPC faculty can respond to the ambiguity of innovative AI policy directives is to consider newer generative AI tools within the broader scope of writing technologies. Gonzales (2023) noted that although generative AI tools are new, broader AI use in writing (and in writing classrooms) has been present for some time and has typically been leveraged by faculty and administrators rather than students. She argued that the current "fear and anger stem from the fact that [AI] can be used by those who are typically on the receiving end of oppressive technologies" (p. 214). In integrating AI tools into TPC courses, then, faculty should consider how a punitive approach to AI detection through tools such as Turnitin can disproportionately target students who rely on various forms of AI assistance (e.g., from tools such as Grammarly, which can also trigger

Turnitin's AI detection) to approximate dominant language norms. Further, discussing AI detection tools (and their reliability) with TPC students can lead to productive critiques of the types of voice, style, and structure that AI writing favors and help students understand their roles as human coauthors, editors, and deliverers of AI-generated content.

Likewise, TPC faculty can consider how integrating AI might make some workplace writing genres more equitable and accessible for students by giving them more opportunities to experiment with a wide array of writing tools and develop strategies for exercising agency when writing with technology. For instance, Dobrin (2023), outlining multiple ways in which AI support has helped writers with genres such as *résumés* and cover letters for years, suggested that writers can "converse with GenAI" (p. 88) to analyze job ads and more appropriately tailor their job-search documents. Because job-search documents are also likely to be read by AI tools (Das, 2023), working with an AI coauthor at the outset may help students better understand how their writing is likely to be received by not only its human audience but its initial AI audience. Indeed, we have begun offering students (optional) AI-generated feedback on some writing activities in addition to our own feedback in order to foster conversations about the kinds of values about writing and language use that are embedded within the GenAI models. Thus, rather than treating the use of AI as a dirty secret, TPC instructors might pursue coauthorship with AI tools to help students "strategically de-identify with their writing," as Findlay (2019, p. 118) found that professional writers on Twitter (now X) frequently do. We believe that integrating AI in workplace writing genres to enhance equity and accessibility, providing students with diverse tools and experimentation opportunities, and fostering strategic coauthorship are all worthy goals for TPC faculty in approaching AI use in the classroom.

Although many universities have shifted the responsibility for AI policy-making to instructors or departments but still seem to advise adhering to existing academic integrity policies, TPC faculty can view this ambiguity as an opportunity for what ATLAS.ti called "collaborative decision-making" with students. While having a policy that is set by the university or department can be reassuring (Cardon et al., 2023), these policies, based on currently available data, are unlikely to reflect the writing practices that TPC faculty need to prioritize in their courses in order to prepare students for the AI-enhanced workplace. But TPC faculty can contribute meaningfully to broader institutional conversations about academic integrity, ideally by drawing (as we have) on their own experiments with AI-assisted writing, to try to avoid an overly narrow framing of discussions

of AI's potential. As TPC faculty grapple with the transformative potential of AI tools, we must acknowledge and address the substantial changes and uncertainties that lie ahead. We recognize that there are legitimate apprehensions about integrating AI-assisted writing in academic settings, particularly involving academic integrity. At the same time, the evolving landscape necessitates that TPC faculty take a proactive approach in their classrooms, one that deeply engages with GenAI tools and with students to consider and shape AI policies. This approach, we believe, will lead to learning environments that prepare students for the challenges and opportunities of using AI tools to enhance their writing in the workplace.

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The authors declared no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

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